



WINNER OF 28 PULITZER PRIZES FOR EXCELLENCE IN JOURNALISM

Chicago Tribune



QUESTIONS? CALL 1-800-TRIBUNE

SATURDAY, JANUARY 11, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

From goat snacks to garden mulch, recycling Christmas trees reduces landfill emissions during time of the year when household waste rises 25%



A goat at Urban Growers Collective in Chicago helps recycle Christmas trees on Tuesday. The goats strip the trees bare, and their manure is composted. What little is left of the trees is later run through a wood chipper. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

YULETIDE TRASH OR TREASURES?

By Adriana Pérez
Chicago Tribune

Each holiday season the United States produces millions of tons of food and shopping waste. Attending festive gatherings and exchanging gifts between Thanksgiving and New Year's Day, American households generate 25% more waste than at any other time of year.

And real Christmas trees are a major part of the problem when people fail to recycle them, experts and environmentalists say.

As seasonal decorations are put away and discarded, these trees are often tossed in the trash. They end up in landfills where — lacking oxygen and unable to break down and return to the soil — they decompose and release methane, a greenhouse gas more than 25 times as powerful as carbon dioxide in trapping heat.

But there are many alternatives, including mulch for gardens, food or activities for animals and even a habitat for your backyard.

“This is family-friendly. You get to come down to the South Side and visit the farm a bit. And hopefully, people come back later in the spring and the summer to see how the farm actually operates and how we utilize the goats throughout the year.”

— Mykele Deville, farm program coordinator at Urban Growers Collective

At the Urban Growers Collective's 8-acre farm in South Chicago, Nigerian pygmy goats chomp, munch and strip the branches of real former Christmas trees that have been dropped off. Whatever they don't eat gets processed and turned into wood chips to sprinkle around the property.

“After the holidays, everybody is just going to fill up the garbage cans,” said Malcolm Evans, director of farms. “This is just a good way of giving back, using everything.”

While over 75% of Americans planned to display an artificial tree this past December, citing reusability, low maintenance, easy setup, sustainability and long-term savings, even these trees present a disposal problem. They can be reused year to year, but trees made from plastic or aluminum eventually end up in a landfill and stay there for centuries. Also, most artificial trees get shipped to the United States from China, adding to carbon emissions.

Turn to Trees, Page 4

HUSH MONEY CASE

Trump avoids fines, prison

President-elect will return to Oval Office as felon, but otherwise no punishment

By Michael R. Sisak, Jennifer Peltz, Jake Offenhartz and Michelle L. Price
Associated Press

NEW YORK — President-elect Donald Trump was sentenced Friday to no punishment in his historic hush money case, a judgment that lets him return to the White House unencumbered by the threat of a jail term or a fine.

With Trump appearing by video from his Florida estate, the sentence quietly capped an extraordinary trial rife with moments unthinkable in the U.S. only a few years ago.

It was the first criminal prosecution and first conviction of a former U.S. president and major presidential candidate.

The New York case became the only one of Trump's four criminal indictments that has gone to trial and possibly the only one that ever will. And the sentencing came 10 days before his inauguration for his second term.

In roughly six minutes of remarks to the court, a calm but insistent Trump called the case “a weaponization of government” and “an embarrassment to New York.” He maintained that he did not commit any crime.

“It's been a political witch hunt. It was done to damage my reputation so that I would lose the election and, obviously, that didn't work,” the Republican president-elect said by video, with U.S. flags in the background.

Beside him at his Mar-a-Lago property was defense lawyer Todd Blanche, whom Trump has tapped to serve as

Turn to Trump, Page 6

IMPERIALIST VISON: Donald Trump has been embracing a new, imperialist agenda, threatening to seize the Panama Canal and Greenland — perhaps by military force — and saying he will use economic coercion to pressure Canada to become the nation's 51st state. **Nation & World in Business, Page 6**

Face of Pritzker's pandemic response violated ethics law

Ezike fined for leaving post to head city hospital system

By Dan Petrella
Chicago Tribune

Dr. Ngozi Ezike, the public face of Gov. JB Pritzker's response to the COVID-19 pandemic, has been fined \$150,000 for violating a state revolving-door ethics law when she left her job as director of the Illinois Department of Public Health in March 2022 to become president and CEO of Sinai Chicago hospital system.

Ezike agreed to pay the fine and admitted the infraction to settle a complaint brought in October 2023 after the state executive inspector general found she'd violated the ethics law, according to records released Friday by the state's Executive Ethics Commission. Her final state salary was \$180,000 annually, and tax

records show she received about \$490,000 from Sinai in the year ending June 30, 2023.

State records show the \$150,000 fine is the third-largest in the ethics commission's two-decade history. A recent story in the Tribune's “Culture of Corruption” series detailed weaknesses in the state's ethics oversight system, including that the vast majority of fines levied by the commission have come in just a handful of cases similar to Ezike's.

In the settlement agreement with the Illinois attorney general's office, Ezike admitted violating a revolving-door prohibition that bars high-ranking state officials from going to work for a vendor within one year of leaving government employment if the agency they helped lead had contracts with a company totaling more than \$25,000 or that the agency was involved

Turn to Ethics, Page 2

WHAT EZIKE VIOLATED: The revolving-door ethics law bars high-ranking state officials from going to work for a vendor under some circumstances. In addition, the inspector general also found Ezike violated a 2015 executive order prohibiting state employees from entering employment negotiations with entities that are registered to lobby their agency.

INSIDE



HANS GUTKNECHT/LOS ANGELES DAILY NEWS

Los Angeles fires persist, but growth slows

Since the flames erupted in and around Los Angeles, scores of residents have returned to their still-smoldering neighborhoods even as the threat of new fires persisted and the nation's second-largest city remained unsettled. For some, it was a first look at the staggering reality of what was lost as the region grapples with the gargantuan challenge of overcoming the disaster and rebuilding. **Nation & World**

